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eyush Bansal believes that as an entrepreneur, choosing the right partners early on

makes a big difference to a company's fortunes. The Co-founder, Chief Executive Officer and Chief People Officer of Lenskart, an e-commerce portal for eyewear, is on a mission to provide spectacles to 50 per cent of the people in India and says the country presents a huge opportunity as 90 per cent of the eyewear market is unorganised. And while the Indian market has undergone a huge transformation, the former Microsoft employee says that Lenskart does have international ambitions in the long term. In a freewheeling interview with *Business Today's* Global Business Editor *Udayan Mukherjee*, Bansal talks about his journey, how Lenskart wants to create a global impact, and his *Shark Tank* experience. Edited excerpts:

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Q: Peyush, you were entrenched into a career track in the US with Microsoft when you suddenly turned course and said, 'I'm going to do something of my own—a private enterprise, and that too focussed on eyewear'. What was the genesis of this transformation?

A: Well, I was at Microsoft and quite inspired by the impact that its products had on the lives of ordinary people—you know stuff like Excel and PowerPoint—and I wanted to do something similar with my life... [and] leave an impression. That is when I decided to quit and reboot.

I came to India literally with no business plan but kept exploring opportunities [that] would make that kind of impact and started working on student housing as a problem. [And did it] for a few years [but it] wasn't big enough. Then I read articles about how India is the blind capital of the world. How 75 per cent of people who need glasses don't wear them; and almost 50-60

per cent of India today needs glasses. It looked like one of those far-reaching problems that hadn't been solved [yet]. My grooming at Microsoft was all about using technology to solve problems. Then one thing led to another and it's been almost a decade now. And I still feel we can work on it for another two-three decades to complete that transformation. But, it definitely is one of those spaces where I can say I have found my own calling in terms of the impact I wanted to create on the lives of ordinary people.

Q: Along the way, you have had the benefit of mentorship from some of the smartest minds in business—from an early angel investor like Ronnie Screwvala, later a legend like Ratan Tata, and then an iconic PE fund like SoftBank. Would you say their contributions were significant, not just in terms of capital but also insights and confidence?

A: Oh absolutely! In fact, my first investor was Chiratae [Ventures], formerly IDG Ventures. The partners there—Sudhir Sethi and TCM [T.C. Meenakshisundaram]—were my early mentors followed by Ronnie [Screwvala], who continues to be my biggest mentor till date. I learnt about work culture and how to build an organisation that is sustainable from Ronnie; from TCM I learnt about how to spend time on growth. SoftBank and KKR brought in serious long-term thinking, dreaming much bigger than I ever could. So yes, I would say choosing the right partners early on makes a huge

“We are not a company that only thinks three years ahead. We are thinking 7-10 years ahead and from that perspective, we have to think international [markets]... [In terms of impact] if there was a Netflix to Disney, there has to be a Lenskart to Luxottica”

difference. I don't think Lenskart would be what it is today, wouldn't be what it will be tomorrow, if it wasn't for these partners.

Again, I've been fortunate that our first early-stage investors are still investors in Lenskart and participated quite uniquely in our last round of